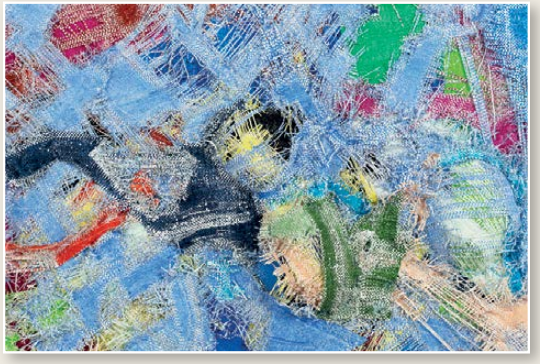
ART

HER DARK MATERIALS

AADITI JOSHI'S FIRST SOLO SHOW IN DELHI CASTS A CRITICAL EYE AT THE USE OF POLYPROPYLENE BAGS, WITH THE MATERIAL ITSELF BECOMING A STATEMENT







RAW MATERIAL All paintings 'Untitled'

Tensile Dimensions is on till October 26 at Nature Morte Gallery, New Delhi

A new exhibition in Delhi highlights the ability to transform recycled plastics—specifically polypropylene bags—into art pieces. Blurring the lines between painting, sculpture and textile, Aaditi Joshi's artworks continue her earlier series, where she explores the versatility of repurposed polypropylene woven bags used for transport of sand and concrete.

The material is intrinsically connected to the Mumbai-based artist's observations of the city's rapidly industrialising landscape, its physical transformation as well as the underlying tensions between industrial progress and ecological responsibility. "The evolving urban sprawl, the juxtaposition of development and decay, and the changing relationship between humans and their environment have all inspired this body of work," she says.

Joshi treats polypropylene with a free expression, allowing paint to flow organically across the surface. Through this, the material evolves into an entirely new form. "I saw a significant transformation, where dismantling and recreating occurred simultaneously," she says. The creation of lifted bumps reflects the material's latent potential for depth and movement.

Freshly manufactured polypropylene offers pristine quality, flexibility and ease of manipulation. It ensures consistency in terms of colour, texture and durability. "By using a fresh plastic bag, my artwork serves as a critique of the prevalence of single-use plastics. It emphasises the unnecessary use of virgin plastic materials and their environmental consequences, all the while showing how even a brand new layer of a PP bag can be creatively repurposed," explains the artist.

For Joshi, working with repurposed polypropylene bags is a deliberate commentary on the collision between urban expansion and environmental decay. "The colours I used weren't selected, but inherited from the industrial process, which became my working palate, turning the raw material's history into part of the narrative," she says. The printed text on the bags further emphasises this, serving as remnants of the city's relentless growth. "The material became a statement, reflecting the stark reality of a metropolis caught between progress and the ecological consequences that follow," she says.

Joshi says the direction of her work evolves organically. "What inspires me along the way often leads to the next phase of development, allowing the work to grow naturally and intuitively," she says. ■

-Neha Kirpal